Hazarika)[71] and a former Congress district president from the tribal area of Karbi Anglong (Sum Ronghang).[72]

As many as 50 per cent of ministers in the BJP's first Assam government were important leaders in other parties before they hitched their fortunes to the BJP (see Table 16.1). All of them had left their original parties before assembly polls in these states—they defected and contested elections on BJP tickets. The party opened its doors to top leaders from both the AGP and the Congress before the 2014 Lok Sabha elections, and leaders from these parties joined it in droves.[73] Twelve of the BJP's sixty Assam MLAs (20 per cent) elected in 2016 had served as MLAs of other parties in the previous assembly.[74] That so many of them were rewarded with ministerial berths established their importance and sent out a message to other regional leaders about the BJP's flexibility and willingness to co-opt.

When I analysed the backgrounds of all BJP ministers in five north-eastern states between 2016 and 2020, I found that Assam was not an aberration. In fact, it turned out that 50 per cent of the ministerial berths for defectors from other parties was the lowest benchmark in the five states I analysed (see Table 16.1). In Manipur, this ratio was as high as 80 per cent in favour of defector-ministers. In Meghalaya and Arunachal, it was 100 per cent.

In Tripura, the chief minister at the time was a BJP true-blood with an RSS background. Even so, 50 per cent of its first ministers (three of six) had previously been legislators with the Congress or the Trinamool Congress.[75] As in Assam, a host of senior leaders from across Tripura's political spectrum joined the party in the months leading up to the election.[76] And, like in Assam, as many as ten (28 per cent) of the BJP's thirty-five winning MLAs in 2018 had previously been legislators or ministers with other parties.[77]

Thanks to this conscious policy of rewarding defectors, the BJP became the party of upward mobility for many leading politicians in the Northeast. This also meant that it could co-opt big leaders with minimal disruption to existing power structures. When they switched sides, it was a simple exchange of the patronage of older parties with that of the BJP, without radical social shifts below that level.